

What A Histogram Shows

If the process map shows how work moves, the histogram shows how much the work varies.

The Average Hides

Most people ask for the average, and it feels reassuring because it is one tidy number for a slide. But the average is one of the most dangerous numbers in business, because it hides everything interesting. The old joke fits. A man with his head in the oven and his feet in the freezer is, on average, perfectly comfortable. Variation is where the truth lives.

How It Works

A histogram is a special kind of bar chart. You sort your data points into buckets and draw a bar for how many landed in each. What you get is a picture of the shape of your data, something an average can never show. It makes variation visible at a glance.

Reading The Shape

The shape tells you things the average cannot. Is the data tightly clustered or spread all over. Is it lopsided, with a long tail of slow cases. Are there two separate humps, which almost always means two different processes are hiding inside one. The average flattens all of that into a single point.

Remember this

The average gives you a number; the histogram gives you the truth about variation.